

JnJ terminates JNJ-95475939 (IL-4R/IL-31 bispecific antibody) phase 2b in AtD based on efficacy data



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Summary

The phase 2b DUPLEX-AD proof-of-concept study evaluated JNJ-95475939 (IL-4R/IL-31 bispecific antibody) for the treatment of moderate to severe atopic dermatitis (AtD). The results of a planned interim analysis met prespecified criteria for early termination of the study, as they did not meet the high-bar efficacy JnJ established for advancing its clinical development programs for AtD. No further details are disclosed.

Why it Matters: The disappointing results from JnJ's IL-4R/IL-31 bispecific antibody highlight the significant uncertainties in drug development for AtD, though both IL-4R and IL-31 are established targets for AtD. Currently, there is increased interest in developing bispecific antibodies for other autoimmune diseases, but no clear frontrunner has emerged. In the coming months, more clinical data on multi-specific antibodies for various combinations are anticipated.

Key Highlights

- JnJ terminated the phase 2b study of JNJ-95475939 versus dupilumab versus placebo after a prespecified interim analysis showed no efficacy, though the asset was well-tolerated and no numerical data was disclosed.
- Recall, the company had [acquired](#) the molecule (originally NM26-2198) from Yellow Jersey Therapeutics, stopped Yellow Jersey's phase 1 trial early after reviewing healthy volunteer data, and advanced directly to phase 2b in Feb'25. The move signals JnJ's strategy of taking to stay ahead of competition.
- Additionally, JnJ previously [acquired](#) proteologix for \$850 million, gaining PX128 (an IL-13/TSLP bispecific antibody phase 1-ready for asthma) and PX130 (an IL-13/IL-22 bispecific antibody in preclinical development for AtD).

Details

- Trial details:
 - JnJ posted the phase 2b study of JNJ-95475939 with the active comparator dupilumab for the treatment of participants with moderate-to-severe AtD (read more about the trial in details [Link to the Vital Post](#)).
- Background related to this molecule
 - JnJ has acquired this molecule through definitive agreement with Numab, under which it acquired Yellow Jersey Therapeutics, a wholly owned subsidiary of Numab, including global rights to NM26 (NM26-2198) in an all-cash transaction worth approximately \$850 million ([Link to the Vital Post](#)).
 - Yellow Jersey Therapeutics previously conducted a Ph1a/Ib trial which was designed to evaluate safety, tolerability, PK, and immunogenicity of single (SAD) and multiple doses (MAD) of NM26 2198 involving healthy volunteers and adult patients with moderate-to-severe AtD.
 - The trial was terminated following the acquisition of Yellow Jersey Therapeutics by JnJ, as per ClinicalTrials.gov, the trial achieving minimum objectives necessary to inform safety, tolerability, and dose selection for Ph2 dose-ranging evaluation of NM26-2198 in healthy volunteer cohorts fully completed. However, the company has not disclosed any results from the Phase 1 trial. JnJ has initiated a Ph2b study in patients with moderate-to-severe AtD.

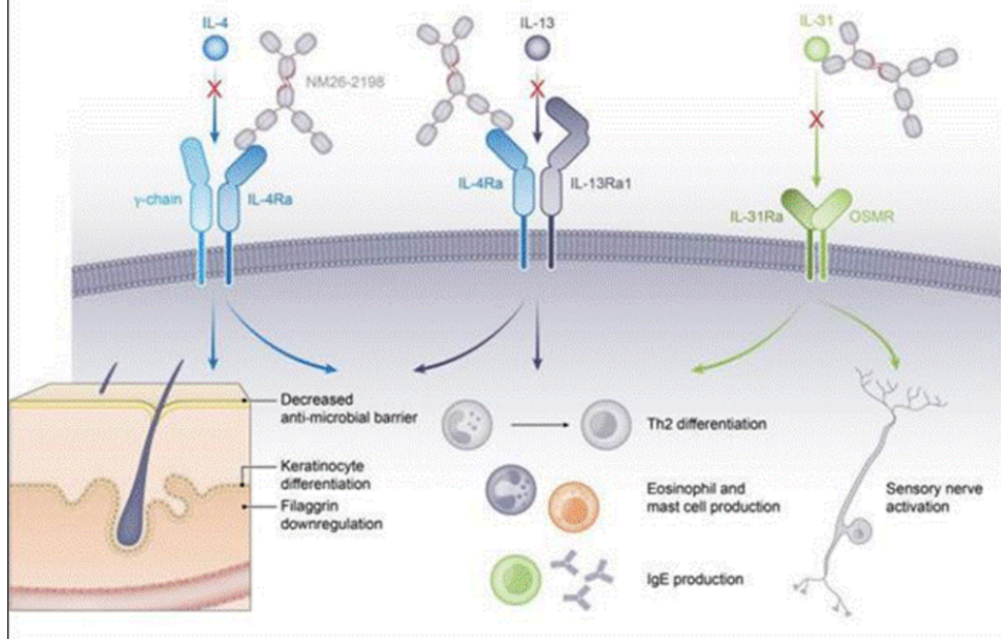
Observations/Comments:

JNJ-95475939 (NM26: IL-4R/IL-31 bispecific antibody):

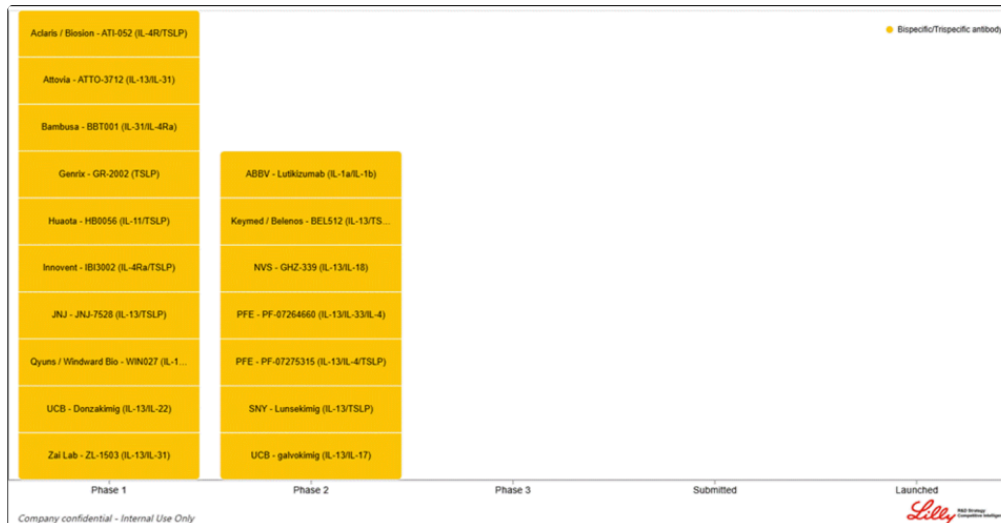
- JNJ-95475939 is a bispecific antibody which targets IL-4Rα (type I and type II receptors) and IL-31 for the treatment of AtD.
- The antibody was discovered and engineered using Numab's proprietary MATCH™ technology platform. JNJ-95475939 (NM26-2198) was designed to prevent IL-4/IL-13 and IL-31-induced keratinocyte immunopathology, immune cell activation, skin barrier function impairment, and pruritus.
- For now, JNJ-7528 remains the only other AtD candidate in JnJ's public pipeline, with phase 1 initiated and phase 2b initiation planned for Feb'26.

Mechanism of Action:

Simultaneous blockade of inflammation and pruritus through targeting of IL-4/IL-13 and IL-31 pathways



- Key competitive landscape of Key bispecific/trispecifics antibodies in AtD space in early clinical development



Sources

JnJ PR ([Link](#))

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